

# Bridging the Human Memory Gap

How episodic recall fails in traditional vector search

Problem statement

## PHOTO RETRIEVAL: THE PROBLEM

Users search for a photo they know exists, but can't recall the words to find it. The challenge is to reduce the friction that makes retrieval fail, without changing the search algorithm.

## Two ways to search today

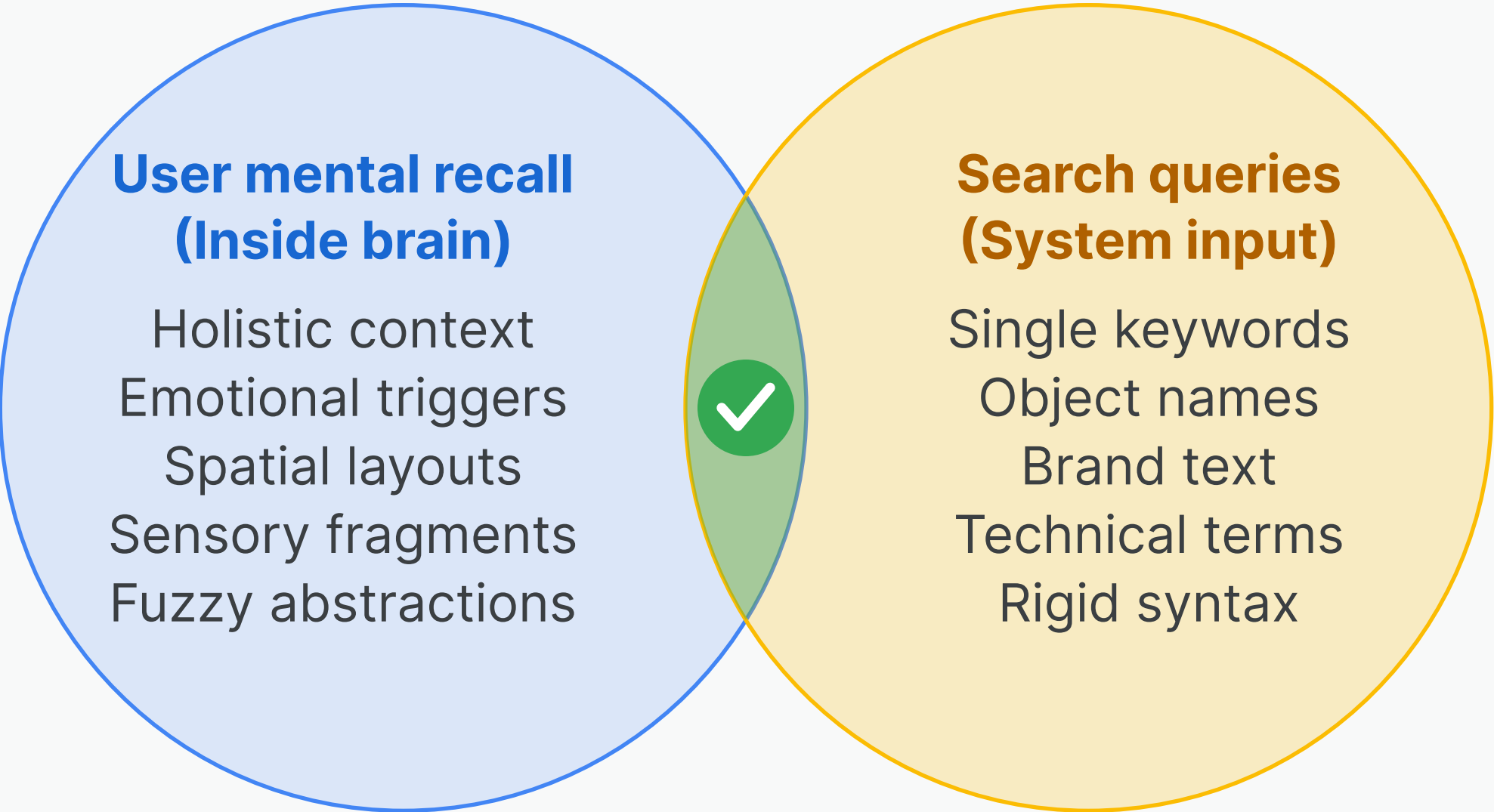
### Classic search

Type keywords into the search box.

### Ask Photos

Chat with your library.  
Get photos, summaries and follow-up questions.

## How users remember a photo



## The Cognitive Mismatch: Explicit Recall vs. Visual Recognition

The product demands precise text (recall). People rely on instant visual verification (recognition).

### System reality

- Built for exact recall
- Rich sensory memories squeezed into flat search text
- One search bar, silent after a weak query

### User reality

- Spots a photo instantly when cues are shown
- "I know it exists, I'll recognize it, but can't describe it."

Successful retrieval: memory happens to match keywords

Core gap: abandonment at peak need, when memory fails

